

Mark Scheme (Results)

Summer 2026 (Predicted)

Pearson Edexcel GCE

In Economics B (9EB0)

Paper 03: The Economic Environment and Business

PREDICTED PRACTICE PAPER — MODERATE

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General Marking Guidance

- All candidates must receive the same treatment. Examiners must mark the first candidate in exactly the same way as they mark the last.
- Mark schemes should be applied positively. Candidates must be rewarded for what they have shown they can do rather than penalised for omissions.
- Examiners should mark according to the mark scheme not according to their perception of where the grade boundaries may lie.
- There is no ceiling on achievement. All marks on the mark scheme should be used appropriately.
- All the marks on the mark scheme are designed to be awarded. Examiners should always award full marks if deserved, i.e. if the answer matches the mark scheme. Examiners should also be prepared to award zero marks if the candidate's response is not worthy of credit according to the mark scheme.
- Where some judgement is required, mark schemes will provide the principles by which marks will be awarded and exemplification may be limited.
- When examiners are in doubt regarding the application of the mark scheme to a candidate's response, the team leader must be consulted.
- Crossed out work should be marked UNLESS the candidate has replaced it with an alternative response.

Section A — Question 1

Case-study context: the UK coffee shop market.

Question Number	Using Extract B and Figure 1 and an appropriate calculation, discuss the likely impact on UK coffee shops of the rise in global coffee bean prices.	Mark
	<i>Indicative content</i>	
1(a)	Knowledge/understanding 2, Application 2, Analysis 2, Evaluation 2 - Figure 1 shows arabica prices rose from \$1.68/lb (Jan-23) to \$3.12/lb (Nov-24) — a percentage change of approximately 85.7% $((3.12-1.68)/1.68 \times 100)$. - Extract B states that the wholesale price of arabica roughly doubled in the 12 months to November 2024. - A rise in the cost of a key input causes the supply curve for coffee shop output to shift to the left, raising the equilibrium price and reducing the equilibrium quantity. - Branded coffee is relatively price-inelastic in the short run, so chains can pass some of the cost rise through to consumers — Figure 2 shows the average latte price rising from £2.95 (2020) to £3.95 (2024). - Independent cafés and small chains cannot hedge via futures markets and therefore face the full impact of spot price rises on margins. - However, the extent of pass-through depends on competitive pressure — the long tail of independents described in Extract A may constrain pricing power. - Substitution to at-home coffee (Extract C — 14% rise in home coffee machine sales) represents a credible substitute and limits how far prices can rise without demand falling. - In evaluation, much depends on whether the bean-price shock is temporary (weather-linked) or structural, and on the firm's ability to hedge future purchases.	(8)

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Level 3	6–8	Accurate knowledge and understanding, supported throughout by use of relevant evidence which is well chosen. Arguments are developed, using logical, coherent chains of reasoning. A balanced awareness of competing arguments.

Demonstrating application (AO2) in responses

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Question Number	Assess the likely effect of the changes in UK consumer incomes and confidence described in Extract C on the revenue of UK coffee shop chains.	Mark
	<i>Indicative content</i>	
1(b)	Knowledge/understanding 2, Application 2, Analysis 3, Evaluation 3 • Extract C reports UK CPI of 2.3% (April 2024) rising to 2.6% (Nov 2024), with a modest recovery in real disposable income. • 38% of UK adults are buying coffee out less often, and home coffee machine sales grew 14% — a structural substitution away from out-of-home coffee. • A rise in real incomes is expected to increase quantity demanded for normal goods; coffee shop visits have positive income elasticity of demand. • Figure 2 shows sector revenue grew from £5.2bn (2023) to £5.6bn (2024), consistent with modest recovery. • However, the 38% reduction in frequency is a meaningful volume signal — rising prices (Figure 2) may offset volume losses, but the structural shift to at-home consumption may persist. • Cautious consumer confidence dampens the transmission from higher incomes to higher café spend. • Evaluation should consider that income elasticity varies across customer segments — premium customers are less sensitive, occasional customers more so. • A rise in revenue does not necessarily mean a rise in profit if cost inflation (beans, wages) outpaces price increases — Figure 2 and Extract B support this. • Judgement: revenue likely to grow modestly, driven more by pricing than volume.	(10)

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Question Number	Assess the extent to which the UK coffee shop market can be described as an oligopoly, using evidence from the extracts to support your answer.	Mark
	<i>Indicative content</i>	
1(c)	Knowledge/understanding 2, Application 2, Analysis 4, Evaluation 4 • An oligopoly is a market dominated by a small number of interdependent firms, typically with high barriers to entry and non-price competition. • Extract A supports the oligopoly view: Costa, Starbucks and Pret together account for more than half of branded outlets — a high three-firm concentration ratio. • Barriers to entry are substantial: £250,000 fit-out cost, 10–15 year lease commitments. • Non-price competition is evident — loyalty apps, plant-based milks, speed of service, ambience, mobile ordering. • However, Extract A also describes a 'long tail of independent and regional coffee shops' growing steadily — suggesting a more fragmented market closer to monopolistic competition. • Substitutes exist: home coffee (Extract C), supermarket cafés, Greggs — reducing market power of the leading chains. • Geographic market definition matters: in a town centre the market may look much more oligopolistic than on a national scale. • Price rigidity and limited price wars support the oligopoly description, although the evidence here is indirect. • Evaluation: the branded chain market is oligopolistic; the total coffee-shop market (including independents and substitutes) is closer to monopolistic competition. • Judgement depends on market definition — a nuanced answer will recognise both.	(12)

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Question Number	With reference to Extract D and your own knowledge, evaluate the case for UK government intervention to reduce the external costs associated with disposable coffee cups.	Mark
	<i>Indicative content</i>	
1(d)	Knowledge/understanding 4, Application 4, Analysis 6, Evaluation 6 • Disposable cups generate a negative externality of consumption/production: private cost to consumer is below social cost (landfill, litter, plastic waste). • Extract D: 2.5bn cups per year, recycling rate below 1 in 400 — large volume, limited private incentive to reduce. • Candidates may draw a negative externality diagram showing MPC, MSC, MSB, with welfare loss triangle, and a Pigouvian tax (latte levy) correcting the mispricing. • Case FOR intervention: (i) the externality is systematically under-priced; (ii) the 5p plastic-bag levy reduced bag use by over 85% — a strong behavioural analogue; (iii) voluntary discounts have <5% uptake (Extract D), demonstrating market/behavioural failure; (iv) revenue from a levy could be hypothecated to recycling infrastructure. • Case AGAINST intervention: (i) regressive — a flat levy is a larger share of low-income consumers' budgets; (ii) government failure risk — revenue not hypothecated; (iii) firms may absorb the levy rather than pass it on, blunting the behavioural nudge; (iv) displacement to non-levied substitutes (cold drinks, bottled water); (v) disproportionate compliance cost for independents relative to Costa/Starbucks. • Alternative policies: producer regulation (mandatory compostable cups, extended producer responsibility), information campaigns, higher voluntary BYO discounts, deposit-return schemes. • Effectiveness depends on: (i) the level of the levy — 25p may be too low to change entrenched habits; (ii) availability and price of reusable alternatives; (iii) administrative cost and enforcement; (iv) time horizon — short-run revenue vs long-run habit change. • Micro effects: welfare gains from internalising externality; distributional effects depending on design. • Macro effects: small in scale but aligns with net-zero targets; sets precedent for producer-responsibility regulation across single-use plastics. • A supported judgement (e.g. 'a well-designed levy combined with producer responsibility is likely welfare-improving provided revenue is hypothecated to recycling') is required for Level 4.	(20)

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Level 2	5–9	Elements of knowledge and understanding, using limited relevant evidence. Arguments and chains of reasoning are presented, but connections between causes and consequences are incomplete. Limited attempt to address the question. Comparisons, judgements or conclusions may be attempted, but are unsupported or generic.

Level 3	10–15	Accurate knowledge and understanding, supported by use of relevant evidence to support the argument, developed chains of reasoning, showing understanding of connections between causes and consequences. Arguments are well developed and competing arguments are present although this may lack balance. A conclusion may be attempted but may not show awareness of the significance of competing arguments.
Level 4	16–20	Accurate knowledge and understanding, supported throughout by use of relevant evidence which is well chosen and fully integrated to support the argument, well developed and logical, coherent chains of reasoning, showing full understanding of the question. Arguments are fully developed and evaluated. A full awareness of the validity and significance of competing arguments, leading to nuanced and balanced comparisons, judgements or conclusions.

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Section B — Question 2

Case-study context: *Tesco plc.*

Question Number	Using the data in Figure 3, calculate the percentage change in Tesco's group sales between 2021/22 and 2023/24. Discuss the implications of the change in operating profit margin over the same period for Tesco's shareholders.	Mark
	<i>Indicative content</i>	
2(a)	Knowledge/understanding 2, Application 2, Analysis 2, Evaluation 2 - Percentage change in group sales = $(61,475 - 54,768) \div 54,768 \times 100 = 12.25\%$ (accept 12.2% or 12.3%). - Operating profit margin = $\text{operating profit} \div \text{sales} \times 100$. - Margin moved from 4.83% (2021/22) to 4.56% (2022/23) to 4.60% (2023/24) — overall a slight compression of about 0.23 percentage points. - Sales grew strongly (+12.25%) yet margin fell — costs have risen faster than revenue. - This is consistent with wage-cost pressure (Extract G — NLW +9.8%) and with competitive pricing via Aldi Price Match and Clubcard Prices (Extract F) capping revenue per item. - Implications for shareholders: absolute profit rose (£2,645m → £2,830m); dividend per share rose from 10.90p to 12.10p (2023/24) — shareholder returns increased. - However, margin compression may indicate long-term pricing pressure — earnings growth could stall if volumes do not continue to grow. - Judgement: short-term shareholder returns are positive; long-term sustainability depends on whether margin stabilises or continues to decline.	(8)

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Question Number	With reference to Extract F, assess the strategies Tesco has used to compete with Aldi and Lidl.	Mark
	<i>Indicative content</i>	
2(b)	Knowledge/understanding 2, Application 2, Analysis 3, Evaluation 3 • Price competition: Aldi Price Match covers 700+ everyday lines — neutralises the headline-price argument for switching. • Loyalty-led price discrimination: Clubcard Prices covers ~8,000 lines at up to a third off for 20m+ households — a form of third-degree price discrimination. • Non-price competition: range, convenience, online grocery (1.5m households/week), store format diversity. • Effectiveness: Tesco's UK grocery share rose to 27.9% (10-year high) — tangible evidence that strategies have worked. • Limitations: matches only a subset of lines — a full Aldi basket may still be cheaper; Clubcard creates two-tier pricing perceptions; margin compression (Figure 3). • Evaluation: effectiveness depends on whether loyalty members consolidate spend with Tesco vs cherry-picking discounted lines; on discounters' continued store expansion; on wider competitor responses (Sainsbury's Nectar Prices, Morrisons More Card). • Judgement: the combination of price-matching and loyalty-segmented pricing has been effective, though at a margin cost; probably a necessary rather than a sufficient response.	(10)

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Question Number	Assess the likely impact on Tesco of the rise in the UK National Living Wage described in Extract G.	Mark
	<i>Indicative content</i>	
2(c)	Knowledge/understanding 2, Application 2, Analysis 4, Evaluation 4 • NLW rose by 9.8% to £11.44 in April 2024; Tesco voluntarily raised store colleague minimum to £12.02 with total reward above £14/hour. • Negative effects: higher wage bill raises marginal cost; margin compressed from 4.83% to 4.60% (Figure 3); price pass-through limited by Aldi Price Match (Extract F); may accelerate substitution of capital for labour (self-service checkouts). • Positive effects: efficiency-wage argument — higher pay improves recruitment, retention, productivity, lowering training costs; higher incomes for low-paid workers generate additional consumer demand, some of which returns to Tesco (multiplier effect); ESG credentials benefit. • Impact depends on: (i) Tesco's ability to pass cost to consumers — limited by discounter competition; (ii) productivity offset via automation; (iii) whether competitors face the same NLW uplift (they do — levelling effect); (iv) the size of wages relative to total costs (wages are ~10–12% of Tesco's cost base, so a 9.8% rise ≈ a 1% absolute cost uplift — meaningful but manageable). • Labour market context: UK unemployment 4.3%, vacancies elevated — labour market tight, so attracting staff may already have required voluntary pay rises. • Evaluation: net impact likely modestly negative for margin in the short run, but manageable given scale; long-run impact depends on productivity response.	(12)

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Question Number	Evaluate the extent to which Tesco's future financial performance depends on macroeconomic conditions in the UK rather than on decisions taken by the firm's own management.	Mark
	<i>Indicative content</i>	
2(d)	Knowledge/understanding 4, Application 4, Analysis 6, Evaluation 6 • Macroeconomic drivers: inflation, real disposable income, interest rates, unemployment, exchange rates, wage legislation (NLW). • Managerial drivers: pricing strategy, product range, store portfolio, supply chain, labour policy, capital investment, portfolio decisions (e.g. sale of Tesco Bank). • Synoptic application — macro side: CPI near 2% target (Extract C); real incomes recovering; NLW +9.8% (Extract G); unemployment 4.3%. These drive volumes and costs. • Synoptic application — management side: Aldi Price Match, Clubcard Prices (Extract F); sales +12.25%; UK market share up from 27.1% to 27.6% (Figure 3) — market-share movement isolates the effect of management decisions from macro conditions that affect all competitors alike. • Case for macro dominance: grocery demand is relatively inelastic but real incomes set the volume ceiling; NLW is set by government and affects the whole industry; interest rates affect consumer confidence and Tesco's financing cost; exchange rates drive the cost of imported food and non-food. • Case for management dominance: market share is a within-industry metric that strips out macro — Tesco's 0.8pp gain represents roughly £1.8bn of additional annual revenue attributable to competitive execution; strategic choices (Aldi Price Match, Clubcard, Booker, Tesco Bank sale) are management decisions; automation and supply-chain investment drive margin. • Micro diagram: candidates may show price-discrimination diagram for Clubcard (first-vs-second tariff) or a cost-curve diagram showing operating leverage. • Macro diagram: AD/AS showing the effect of rising real incomes on the grocery sector, or a labour-market diagram showing the impact of a binding NLW. • Evaluation: short-run performance more macro-sensitive (cost-of-living squeeze in 2022/23 visible in margin compression); long-run performance more management-driven (capability, innovation, capital allocation); severity of macro shock matters — a deep recession would dominate excellent management; mild cycles let management effects show. • A supported judgement (e.g. 'in a normal macro environment, management decisions dominate relative performance; in a severe shock, macro conditions dominate') is rewarded at Level 4.	(20)

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